



Run machines: In the batting department, England will rely on openers Zak Crawley and Ben Duckett, backed up by Harry Brook and the ever-reliable Joe Root (below).

Stokes' men, a result that mustn't be spoken of even in hushed tones. Armed with clarity of the binary world of winning or losing, England is unrecognisable, in spirit and in letter. Only five members of England's last Test down under, in Hobart, have made the journey this time. Meanwhile, 10 Australians from that game are likely to feature in this Ashes, and nine of them are set to play the opener in Perth.

It is a generational battle of sorts. Australia's 15-member squad for the first Test, which skipper Pat Cummins and Josh Hazlewood will miss due to injury, includes 14 players over 30, with all-rounder Cameron Green the lone exception. England's 16-man roster has nine players yet to turn 30, and 11 who still haven't played a Test in Australia. **The baggage of 13 defeats and two draws in England's last 15 Tests in Australia since its last triumph in 2011 is unlikely to weigh heavily on a young brigade bracing for its toughest challenge.**

But forewarned is forearmed. This may be the last Ashes hurrah at home for the likes of Steve Smith, Usman Khawaja, Scott Boland, Hazlewood, Nathan Lyon and

Mitchell Starc, members of Australia's old guard who will once again be at the vanguard of protecting the fortress and the urn, which has been in its possession since 2018.

However, some challenges confront the host, and they start from the very top. Khawaja, who hasn't scored a fifty in his last 10 Test innings, has had five different opening partners since David Warner retired from the format last year. He could get a sixth if 31-year-old left-hander Jake Weatherald is handed a cap after a prolific run for Tasmania and Australia A over the past year.

Weatherald's debut could pave the way for Marnus Labuschagne's return to his preferred No. 3 spot, from which he

Schedule



First test

November 21-25, Perth

Second test

December 4-8, Brisbane

Third test

December 17-21, Adelaide

Fourth test

December 26-30, Melbourne

Fifth test

January 4-8, Sydney

has cracked five centuries in eight innings across the Sheffield Shield and One-Day Cup to force a recall after being dropped for the West Indies tour. But fielding both Weatherald and Labuschagne leaves Australia with the headache of choosing only one between all-rounders Green and Beau Webster. In sharp contrast, England's opening pair stands tall above their contemporaries. Ben Duckett and Zak Crawley's partnership has yielded 2,511 runs since 2022, and despite their alliance coinciding with England's high-risk Bazball, their average of 46.50 is the highest among the top seven most prolific opening pairs in the corresponding period.

Though confusion persists in Australia's top three, the engine room of Steve Smith and Travis Head, at Nos. 4 and 5, lends assurance. They have been Australia's highest run-getters in Tests since January last year, with strike rates of 55 and 80.85, respectively. But they meet their match in Joe Root and Harry Brook, who hold the same positions and significance in the England line-up. Root's stunning late-career surge has seen him amass 2,127 runs at an average of 57.48, with nine tons and six half-centuries in 23 matches since January 2024.

With the 34-year-old now within touching distance of Sachin Tendulkar's record run tally in the format, it is an opportune

